



loyalty to their region, its customs, and language. Nevertheless, there is much that Italians share despite their regional variations—among these are strong family ties, the Roman Catholic faith, and an utter

obsession with soccer. Traditional features of the daily routine, though less common now, include a midday nap, and the *passeggiata*—an evening stroll instituted more to satisfy the need to see and be seen than for exercise.

CHESS GAME

Every two years a lifesize game of chess is played on an enormous board in the public square of Marostica. Over 500 performers in old-fashioned costumes take part while an audience of 4,000 watch the game.



Eating well

Italians are proud of their healthy Mediterranean diet of pasta, beans, fruit, vegetables, and small amounts of meat, fish, and seafood. A leisurely lunch of three or more courses used to be the main meal of the day but this is changing as more women work outside the home.

As with wine, many factors influence the taste of olive oil—the type of olives used, when they are harvested and pressed, the climate, and the soil where they are grown.

PASTA CHEFS

The Italians did not invent pasta, their national food. However, Italy is the leading producer of durum wheat, which, in the form of semolina, is its main ingredient. On average, every Italian consumes 65 lbs (30 kg) of pasta annually.



STREET FESTIVAL

Italians love their festivals. As well as national holidays, every town and village has its own holidays, often involving communal eating and drinking. Here, tables and chairs have been laid out in the town of San Casciano in Tuscany so that all the locals can join in the feasting.

